that when the Sultan arrived and sat down, the whole court rose and shouted ‘Bismillah!’. A hundred of his armed personal guards stood on either side of the throne. Clearly the Sultan was taking no chances.

Most of the nobility and senior officials would have been foreigners—Turks but also Khurasanis, Egyptians, Syrians and so on. Ibn Batuta tells us that Muhammad Tughlaq systematically gave high positions to foreigners. He was not unusually biased. The Turks would have considered themselves as an army of occupation and Indians—both Hindus and local Muslims—would have been treated with contempt. Indeed, there were periods when Indians would have been tolerated within the walls of medieval Delhi only as slaves, menial workers and other service providers. This attitude only changed under the Afghan Suris in the mid-1500s and was institutionalized under Mughal Emperor Akbar. It was a slow transformation. As Percival Spear points out, even under Akbar, most of the nobility was foreign-born. 21

Ibn Batuta tells us that from time to time, the Tughlaq Sultan held banquets. All the guests would be seated by rank. Each person was first given a cup of ‘candy-water’ that they were expected to drink before they ate. Then, the food would be brought from the kitchen in a procession headed by the Chief Usher holding a golden mace and his deputy holding a silver mace. As they walked by, they would cry out ‘Bismillah!’. The food consisted of rounds of unleavened bread, roast meats, chicken, rice, sweets and, interestingly, samosas. After the meal, each person was given a tin cup of barley water to settle the stomach. Finally, everyone was served paan (betel leaves and areca-nuts). When the meal was finished, the chamberlains cried ‘Bismillah!’ and everyone stood up.

We are not sure exactly where Muhammad Tughlaq’s palace stood but the most likely site is the enigmatic ruins of Bijay Mandal, very close to IIT Gate. Very few tourists visit the site and it appears to be used mostly by the teenage boys of nearby Begumpur village to steal a forbidden drink—there are empty beer bottles everywhere. Just behind the Bijay Mandal complex is the impressive Begumpur Mosque which may have once served as the imperial mosque but, again, is rarely visited by tourists. I found the place